



Granny's House: Home for the Holidays

"It's Christmas in Atlanta, and baby, this house ain't big enough for three generations and one opinionated grandma."

TREATMENT

Let me tell you about the Christmas everything hit the fan and somehow, we still found joy in the middle of the mess.

It all started when Renee, my daughter, bless her heart, lost her job right before the holidays. Life had been life-ing, and she packed up them two kids and moved back into my house here in West End. Now listen, I love my family, but I didn't ask for all that drama at Christmastime. I was planning on a quiet holiday: sweet potato pie, "The Preacher's Wife" on DVD, and maybe a little spiked eggnog after church. Instead? I got a whole lot of opinions, hormones, and attitudes under one roof.

Renee's trying to hold it all together like she ain't got the right to fall apart sometimes. Kiki, my teenage granddaughter, thinks she grown because she got 12,000 followers on TikTok. And Malik, my baby grandson, bless him, is trying to turn my living room into the North Pole with duct tape and glitter. Meanwhile, I'm just trying to make sure we get to Christmas without cussing, crying, or catching a case.

And don't even get me started on Deacon Earl, always showing up with a sweet potato pie and a sermon, talkin' 'bout "Granny, let the Lord use me." I said, "He can use you to go fix that light on the porch."

But baby, the real drama kicked in with this Christmas Jubilee.

Now every year, the whole block competes in this big holiday showdown, lights, music, choir performances, the works. I've been the Jubilee Queen for three years straight and I'll be *darned* if I let the Johnsons across the street outshine me with that inflatable Baby Jesus they got from Home Depot.

But of course, my house turns into a circus:

- Malik almost burns down the garage trying to rig up a light show.
- Kiki signs me up for a TikTok Christmas dance without my permission.
- Renee and I have a big blow-up over dinner, about life, motherhood, and all the things we *don't* say out loud.

Suddenly, everybody's mad, nothing's decorated, and it looks like Christmas might just pass us by.

But here's the thing about family, especially ours: we fight, we fuss, but we *show up*.

One night, the power goes out from a freak snowstorm (yes, snow, *in Atlanta*), and there we are: no Wi-Fi, no distractions, just candles, cocoa, and the truth. That's when it all comes out.

Renee finally admits she's tired of pretending to be strong all the time. Kiki says she misses the way Christmas *used* to feel, when her daddy was still around and Mama still smiled. Malik just wants everyone to stop yelling and eat cookies like a real family.

And me? I tell them the truth, I'm scared too. I don't always know how to comfort my daughter because I was too busy surviving when I was raising her. But that night, we laughed, we cried, and we got real.

By Christmas Eve, baby, we got it together.

We pulled out Malik's janky decorations, lit up the yard with solar lights, and turned that living room into a stage for our own homemade Jubilee. Deacon Earl even played Santa Claus. And yes, I *did* that TikTok dance Kiki taught me bad knee and all. It went viral. Again.

Christmas morning came, and it wasn't perfect. We didn't have piles of gifts or fancy brunch reservations. But we had each other. We had love. And that's all I ever prayed for.